

A DECADE LATER, THE WORLD HAD CHANGED, THE CLEAVAGE STRUCTURE REMAINED

Israel 1996–2006

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ABSTRACT

The defining challenge for Israel since 1967 has been the future of the territories captured in the Six Day War and the population living in them. With the stalemate festering and the salience of the conflict very high, the conflict with the Palestinians has become the major cleavage dimension in Israeli politics. Building on the multidimensional conceptualization of cleavage, we argue that despite the occurrence of many, dramatic, changes, the cleavage structure has not changed in the past decade, and the 1977 realignment is still in place. The primary cleavage is a full and consistent interlocking cleavage. Its potency, and the quality that permits it to achieve this overarching position, is associated with its expression of underlying collective identity dilemmas, which combine external and internal dimensions. Collective identity concerns, more readily than others, produce full cleavages and are likely to dominate and endure, overriding other issues. The establishment, positioning and success of Kadima in the 2006 elections are explicated within this framework.

KEY WORDS ■ collective identity ■ Israel ■ Kadima ■ political cleavage ■ voting behaviour

Introduction

Rent asunder by a persistent split between two opposing views of the political environment, the enemy and the solution, the Israeli polity has been unable to fashion a persistent policy with which to face the combination of Arab intransigence and Palestinian efforts to win independence ever since

the Six Day War in 1967. The more conciliatory policies adopted by some of the leaders some of the time (Rabin, Barak, Sharon) have been associated with dire reactions from some Jews, including assassination, and fierce struggles over legitimacy, as well as the outbreak of violence and terror on the Palestinian side. At other times, less conciliatory positions (Shamir, Netanyahu, Sharon) have been pursued; these policies might have assuaged Jewish militants, but the results have been neither stable nor pacific.

With the stalemate festering and the salience of the conflict very high, electoral and party politics have become a very frustrating enterprise. A decisive electoral victory for one point of view or the other has been unlikely. This has been true because of the divisions in the population and not only due to the need to form coalitions in Israel's parliamentary system. Even in the period in which the direct election of the prime minister was in place (1996–2001) no overwhelming majority emerged to support one point of view or the other.

The theoretical puzzle is how the political system persisted in such conditions and how it managed – or did not manage – other challenges it faced. Put differently, how were social cleavages politicized? What worked against the politicization of cleavages? One might anticipate that in a situation of issue gridlock an enterprising leader or political group would attempt to win power by leveraging a different cleavage into the spotlight of the electoral campaign or to frame old dilemmas in new ways. Did this happen? Did it succeed?

Three dimensions are crucial to understanding political cleavages: (1) a social structural element – an ascriptive or demographic group basis; (2) a normative element related to the set of values and beliefs which provides a sense of identity and gives a role to the social group(s) involved; and (3) an organizational or behavioural element that points to interactions, institutions and organizations, such as political parties, which develop as part of the cleavage (Bartolini and Mair, 1990: 215). Cleavages involve all three of these dimensions:

[They] cannot be reduced simply to the outgrowths of social stratification; rather, social distinctions become cleavages when they are organized as such. . . . A cleavage has therefore to be considered primarily as a form of closure of social relationships. (*Ibid.*, p. 216)

This definition of cleavage is demanding. For a cleavage to express itself in a political system, a good many pieces must be in place. Deegan-Krause's illustration (2007: 540, Figure 28.1), reproduced here, is especially effective in portraying visually that which is hard to grasp abstractly: that the elements of the structure must all be in alignment for the key to work, for the slots in each of the 'wheels' to fall into place, for the lock to release, for the tumblers to disengage.

Issues have maximum impact in the party system if the alignment is complete, if the cleavage is full. Most political attempts involve cleavages

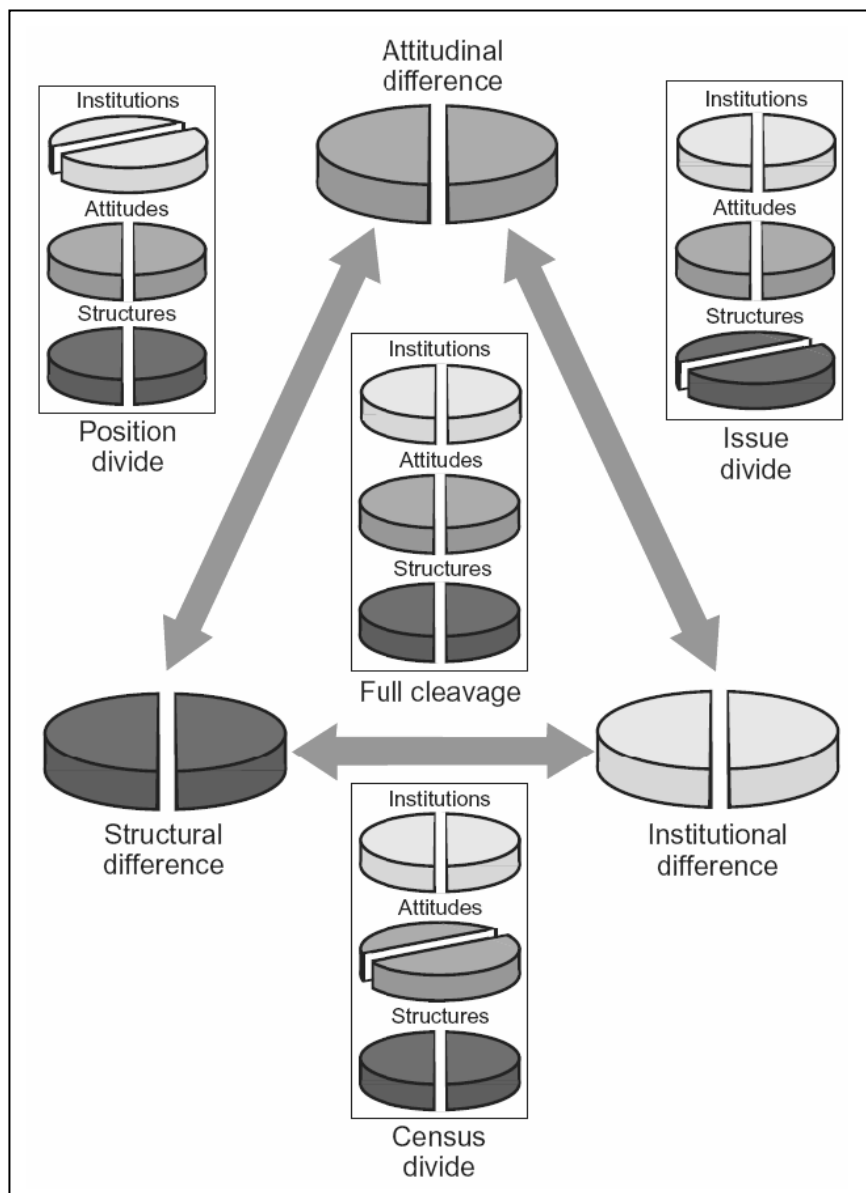


Figure 1. Model of difference, divide, and cleavage

less than full, and this is the background to their partial success. Therefore Deegan-Krause's (2007) call for a clear conceptual distinction between full cleavages and less than full ones is warranted. He suggests labelling one cleavage element, when effective, a difference, two a divide, and only when three cleavage elements are in full alignment, a cleavage. Much of the

confusion of the cleavage literature exists, writes Deegan-Krause, because we confuse different types of cleavage existence.

We build on this theoretical elaboration and argue that despite the appearances of many and dramatic changes the Israeli party system's cleavage structure has been stable ever since the 1977 realignment, and this is rooted in the fact that the primary cleavage is a full cleavage embedded in deeply held collective identity concerns.

Collective Identity and Political Rifts

Differences based on collective identity are more likely to become full cleavages and are likely to dominate and endure. Indeed, religion, ethnicity and linguistic differences seem to have retained their role in party systems, whereas the role of class has weakened (Dalton, 2006: Ch. 8; Esmer and Pettersson, 2007; Knutsen, 2007; Saggar, 2007). Support across ethnic lines is uncommon; ethnic groups usually have parties to represent them, as do religious groups – Christian, Muslim and Jewish (Deegan-Krause, 2007: 549). Where relevant, collective identity-based differences are found to be more significant than other differences in politics (Lijphart, 1979). And such differences will readily produce full cleavages from both bottom-up and top-down (agency and mobilization) perspectives.

Identity signals meaningful distinctions between group members and outsiders, on the one hand, and communality within the group in terms of some consequential social category and the group's goals and orientations, on the other. It binds together symbolic politics and concerns of self-interest, making it an 'easy issue'. Collective identity combines position and structure and triggers voting on policy issues and social allegiance (Shamir and Arian, 1999a). And, exactly for these reasons, collective identity is a natural, easy and useful resource for political agents upon which to mobilize.

The defining cleavage for the Israeli case since 1967 has been the future of the territories captured in the Six Day War and the population living in them. Elections have been fashioned around this issue, careers made or broken, and, most importantly, this issue has clearly been the most important determinant of the vote (Shamir and Arian, 1999a). The conflict with the Palestinians is still the major cleavage dimension, and it is a full and consistent interlocking cleavage in the sense used here. It is not a foreign affairs issue *per se*. The potency of this issue, and the quality that permits it to achieve this overarching position, is associated with its expression of an underlying Jewish–Zionist cohesion providing answers to collective identity dilemmas. It thus produces a cleavage so deep, so stubborn and so intractable that it overrides other issues. Accordingly, social-economic issues could not override it in the 2006 election, and attempts to organize based on other challenges facing Israel, such as the environment, or the gap among social classes, or the tension among various groups – between the religious and secular,

among various ethnic groups, or between immigrants and old-timers in Israel – have not endured, except for the religious parties where the overlap with the conflict dimension of cleavage is overwhelming. A good example from the 2006 election is the Israel Beitenu (Israel is Our Home) party, headed by Avigdor (Yvette) Lieberman, whose electorate was mostly ‘Russian’ immigrants, but its agenda mainly along the conflict dimension. In 2003, Shinui (Change) ran on an anti-Haredi (ultra-Orthodox) platform, avoiding taking a stand on the conflict issue; by 2006 it had disintegrated. It is impossible to achieve significant and long-term standing in the Israeli party system and the Israeli electorate without providing a rallying-cry and at least alluding to some stance regarding the intricacies of security and the territories. Of course, the policy of unilateral disengagement can also be thought of as a means of grappling with the main issues by sidestepping them.

The portrait of Israel as a collection of competing tribes contributes to the logic of identity cleavage politics (Kimmerling, 1999). This attribution has each tribe caring about its material and symbolic benefits in society, but also attempting to imprint its vision on the entire society. The Arab Israeli minority is reluctant with the Zionist vision of Israel as a Jewish state. For the Orthodox religious Jews, promulgating Jewish religious law in the state’s law books is a highly cherished goal. Then there are the distinctions between Jews of Oriental and Ashkenazi origin, and the immigrants from the former Soviet Union (FSU) and Ethiopia.

The central, critical and engulfing issue dimension in Israeli politics is that of the Israeli–Palestinian or Israeli–Arab conflict centred on ‘the territories’. The questions involved pertain to basic collective identity dilemmas of territorial and social communal boundaries, closely tied to these ‘tribal’ distinctions, in particular the Arab–Jewish and the Jewish religious–secular ones. The external dimension relates to the state’s borders and relations with the Palestinians, the Arabs and the rest of the world; the internal aspect concerns the nature of the Jewish state and society. The notion of Israel as a Jewish state is highly problematic for most Israeli Arabs, while it provides a common denominator for most Israeli Jews. However, the meaning assigned by Jews to the Jewish state is dynamic and differs dramatically across groups. This dissensus provides the basis for a struggle between cultures, often defined in terms of religious versus secular, primordial versus civil, Jewishness versus Israeliness or Eretz Israel (the Land of Israel) versus the state of Israel (Kimmerling, 1985). This dimension is closely related to the territorial, external identity dimension, as Eretz Israel is strongly embedded in both Jewish nationalism and religion.

Religion became closely intertwined with nationalism, especially since 1967, as religious authorities provided legitimization to keeping the territories taken in the war of that year, thus establishing the link between the people, their history, God and the land. The settlement movement Gush Emunim (the Block of the Faithful) and the National Religious party played key roles in the long-term process of linking religion and nationalism in

public opinion and in coalition politics. Fuelled by the growing strength of the ultra-Orthodox non-Zionist Haredi camp, and especially the Shas party, the schism along the internal identity dimension sharpened.

The two dimensions of collective identity – external and internal – are operative, and the overlap between them became clearer and stronger over the years. The term ‘Hardal’ (literally mustard), an acronym for Haredi and ‘Dati Leumi’ (national religious), captures this process within the religious sector, whereby national religious Jews grew closer to the Haredim in their religious observance, and the non-Zionist ultra-Orthodox community became more nationalistic regarding the Arab–Israeli conflict. In 2005, when Prime Minister Ariel Sharon led the unilateral disengagement from the Gaza Strip, the amalgamation of the external and internal dimensions of collective identity was manifestly exposed. Many of the settlements that were removed were peopled by Orthodox religious Jews, and the opposition to this move was led and the massive demonstrations against it were manned primarily by Orthodox religious Jews, and largely by settlers.

In terms of the Deegan-Krause model (Figure 1), these dimensions of collective identity represent the attitudinal element of the cleavage, anchored in the national, ethnic and religious diverse mosaic structure of society, and embodied institutionally in the party system. As we will see, this is still a full cleavage in 2006, despite momentous events and developments, and a dynamic society and party system.

1996–2006 – More of the Same

We focus our exploration of political cleavages and collective identity within the Jewish electorate¹ on the comparison between 1996 and 2006. The 1996 election took place at the height of the rupture and polarization, the first election after the Oslo Agreements between Israel and the Palestinians held shortly after the assassination of prime minister Yitzhak Rabin. The 2006 elections, with the newly established centre party, Kadima, winning the election, seems to present a record high in convergence to the centre. We explore first the attitudinal dimension of the cleavage, i.e. collective identity on its two dimensions, to establish its depth and sturdiness. This is followed by bivariate analyses examining its relationship with other attitudinal constructs, with the vote and with major social structural characteristics. Finally, in this section we report multivariate analyses of the vote in the two years that incorporate controls and demonstrate unequivocally the importance of collective identity in party choice.

In the 1996 and 2006 Israel National Election Study (INES) pre-election surveys,² we included several questions intended to measure the collective identity dimensions within the Jewish sample. These items provide the basis for the two identity scales, namely the external identity scale and the internal identity scale.³ The external identity scale was defined by orientation to the

issues of the Israeli–Arab conflict: the territories issue; peace talks; a Palestinian state; the Oslo Agreements in 1996 and unilateral disengagement in Gaza in 2006; and value priority of Greater Israel. The corresponding coefficients were 0.81 in 1996 and 0.77 in 2006. The internal identity scale included the value priority of democracy, the primary identity as Jewish or Israeli, state-religion issue, and the primacy of democracy or Jewish religious law ($\alpha = 0.68$ in 1996, 0.72 in 2006).

The high and similar α coefficients in the two samples indicate the sturdiness of these identity dimensions. Furthermore, the two scales correlated strongly and similarly in both years, i.e. 0.60 in 1996 and 0.62 in 2006, illuminating the powerful relationship between the two dimensions of collective identity which has not receded over this decade.

Both scales were constructed as continua from 1 to 100 and not as dichotomies, but for shorthand purposes we label their poles: for the external identity scale, the poles were Doves and Hawks; for the internal identity scale, the poles were Israeli and Jewish. We cut each of them into three according to the scores obtained: 1–33, 34–66 and 67–100. Their intersection generated nine scale types and these are displayed in Table 1. Using this convention, the percentage of those identifying as Doves (scale types 1, 2 and 3) fell from 39 percent to 34 percent between 1996 and 2006, while the Hawks (scale types 7, 8 and 9) made up 23 percent of each sample. The middle group on the external scale jumped five percentage points from 38 to 43. This change was a result of the failure of the Oslo process and despair from the Palestinians following the failed 2000 Camp David summit and the second Intifada. This shift had been identified by Sharon and capitalized upon in both his disengagement policy and the establishment of Kadima, at the same time that he contributed to it in his policy. On the internal scale, respondents identifying as Israelis (scale types 1, 4 and 7), increased from 37 percent to 42 percent, and respondents identifying as Jews (scale types 3, 6 and 9) made up 27 percent of the respondents in 1996 and 28 percent in 2006. The ‘inconsistent’ identifications of those identifying

Table 1. Scale types,^a 1996 and 2006

	1996				2006			
	<i>Israeli</i>	<i>Middle</i>	<i>Jewish</i>	<i>Total</i>	<i>Israeli</i>	<i>Middle</i>	<i>Jewish</i>	<i>Total</i>
Dove	(1) 25.1	(2) 10.9	(3) 2.9	38.9	24.4	7.9	1.5	33.7
Middle	(4) 9.8	(5) 16.9	(6) 11.5	38.2	14.9	16.0	12.4	43.3
Hawk	(7) 2.3	(8) 8.3	(9) 12.3	22.9	2.8	5.7	14.4	22.9
Total	37.2	36.1	26.7	100%	42.1	29.6	28.3	100%
	(N = 1,039)				(N = 1,412)			

^a Values in the table are percentages of each scale type out of the total for each year. Values in parentheses refer to scale types discussed in the text.

with Dovish and Jewish identities, and those with Hawkish and Israeli identities, were very small in both samples (categories 3 and 7).

Some of the change on both dimensions is attributable to the very large influx of immigrants from the FSU since the beginning of the 1990s. This group was relatively new to the country at the time of the 1996 study and was underrepresented in that year's sample.⁴ Many of the immigrants were strong nationalists, but not familiar with Jewish religious ritual; they constituted a very large voting bloc, with more than a million of them coming after the collapse of the Soviet Union. The shifts in their voting have determined the electoral results in a number of close contests and their parties and politicians have been important in sustaining certain coalitions. The presence of this group in the 2006 sample makes the stability of the numbers even more notable.

We can say that over this decade the Jewish electorate has become somewhat more Israeli on the internal dimension and less dovish and more middle of the road on the external dimension. Table 1 indicates convergence on the external dimension, where the middle category is the one that increased most over this decade, but growing polarization on the internal dimension, where the middle category declined between 1996 and 2006.

The Russian immigration contributed significantly to these changes, but they characterize the long-established residents as well. On the internal dimension, it is the veterans who are responsible for the polarization, with the middle categories among them depleting and both 'Israeli' and 'Jewish' categories swelling. The immigrants watered down this polarization, but were the source of the larger part of the movement of the whole spectrum in the 'Israeli' direction. On the external dimension, convergence to the middle stems primarily from the Russian immigration; old-timers changed slightly, becoming less dovish, and the overall score became more hawkish, due to both groups. In other words, the Russian immigration infused the Israeli polity with 'Israeliness' and hawkishness, highlighting these trends, at a time when veteran Israelis polarized on the internal dimension of identity, and converged slightly while moving to the hawkish pole on the external dimension. The immigrants thus accentuated tendencies in Israeli veteran society, but paradoxically contributed to convergence rather than polarization on both dimensions.

In further uncovering continuity and change, we consider the scale types by attitudes and vote for the two periods (see Table 2).

The two attitudinal variables deepen our understanding of the identity dimension and its place in Israeli politics. The first row provides another angle – from the perspective of threat – on the connection between the internal and external dimensions of identity and its deep roots. There is a strong connection between scale type and threat, which did not change between 1996 and 2006 (eta correlations of 0.52 and 0.49, respectively). The 'Hawks' were much more likely than 'Doves' to perceive the Arabs as wanting to destroy Israel and kill Jews in both samples; also, 'Jewish'

Table 2. Scale types (1–9) by attitudes and vote, 1996 and 2006

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
A. 1996									
% Arab aspirations to destroy Israel and kill Jews (27% of total)	5	6	8	16	24	35	5	48	57
% socialist (48% of total)	52	58	46	42	44	48	50	47	44
% Peres vote (v. Netanyahu; 52% of total)	97	93	92	72	52	32	12	11	4
% Third Way party vote	1	2	0	4	2	2	5	4	1
% Labor vote (37% of total)	72	67	92	42	40	22	5	4	3
% Likud vote (35% of total)	2	9	8	22	35	43	65	72	60
No decision for vote question (8% of total)	2	7	0	15	9	11	15	5	7
B. 2006									
% Arab aspirations to destroy Israel and kill Jews (42% of total)	16	22	32	39	45	60	53	65	75
% socialist (56% of total)	63	56	67	48	47	64	62	53	60
% Kadima vote (24% of total)	35	39	23	35	24	10	21	12	4
% Labor vote (12% of total)	45	19	1	7	16	9	0	1	1
% Likud vote (10% of total)	1	3	0	12	14	16	21	20	12
Undecided for vote (12% of total)	9	11	10	12	14	14	20	19	11

Scale types as defined in Table 1. Values in the table are percentages within each scale type.

respondents were more threatened than 'Israelis', although the differences here were smaller. All scale types became more threatened over this decade.

In contrast to threat perceptions, the classical socio-economic dimension of support for socialist as opposed to capitalist policies was barely related to the two identity dimensions in the two time periods studied (eta correlations of 0.11 and 0.12). It is interesting to point out, though, that just about all scale types (except for category 2) moved in the socialist direction over this decade, and that the most consistent and significant change in the socialist direction can be observed among the three Jewish categories (3, 6 and 9).

Studying the vote intentions for prime minister and for the Knesset (Israel's parliament) in 1996 by scale type is revealing. Among those identified as Hawks measured by the external identity scale (scale types 7, 8 and 9), the vast majority intended to vote for Netanyahu and Likud and just about no one for Peres or Labor – irrespective of their internal scale position. The numbers are astounding. The vote for Netanyahu among types 7, 8 and 9 varied between 88 and 96 percent; the Likud vote of these scale types varied between 60 and 72 percent and that for Labor between 3 and 5 percent. The mirror image is obtained among the three Dove scale positions, with 92 to 97 percent voting for Peres, 2 to 9 percent for Likud and 67 to 92 percent for Labor. The external identity dimension drove these two extreme groups of respondents; the internal identity dimension made virtually no difference in the prime ministerial choice and little difference in the party vote. The internal identity dimension had an impact only for those with no determined position on the external dimension, falling in its middle categories (4, 5 and 6).

In 2006, both Labor and Likud dwindled. Labor was especially successful only among the Dove-Israeli types (scale type 1); Likud appealed more generally among the Hawk-Jewish and middle categories. Both Likud and Labor were severely weakened even among the identity types they did best in. But the story of 2006 was Kadima, the centrist party formed by Prime Minister Ariel Sharon weeks before the stroke that removed him from the political scene. That party appealed to six of the nine scale types at a rate between 20 and 40 percent. It was particularly successful among the Doves and the Israelis, but also among those holding more moderate views. The pattern of 1996 still held for Likud and Labor in 2006, but it was much weaker due to their shrinking; centrist Kadima drew support across the board on both dimensions. The relationship between the collective identity dimension and vote was still very strong in 2006, but less than in 1996. This was a result of the changing attitude distribution, but in particular the change in the institutional dimension of the cleavage with the establishment of Kadima which brought about the demise of the two-bloc structure of the 1990s. The division between left and right combines politics and ideological stance, and in Israeli politics it is defined primarily along the external identity dimension (Arian and Shamir, 2001). Looking at the relationship between left–right self-identification and the collective identity scale types

we find indeed that they are strongly related at both points in time, but in 2006 less so than in 1996 (eta of 0.67 in 1996, 0.50 in 2006).

Since dilemmas of collective identity tie into social groupings, identity types should be related to social characteristics. Table 3 presents the two identity scales in terms of religious observance, the social characteristic with the greatest political significance among Jews. Religious observance matters and is associated with significant differences along the two dimensions, the more striking ones being on the internal identity dimension. The range of the means recorded for the internal dimension was larger than for the external dimension, and the range for 2006 was larger than it was in 1996. The corresponding correlations in 1996 were 0.51 for the internal scale and 0.38 for the external scale; in 2006 these correlations were 0.59 and 0.40. The religious became somewhat more hawkish and somewhat more Jewish between 1996 and 2006, while the secular became to a similar degree more hawkish at the same time that they became more Israeli. Increased polarization along the internal dimension is aligned with the religious–secular divide.

If there is a lock on the cleavage structure by what we have called the dimensions of collective identity, it should show up in the social structural and issue bases of the vote, and in the agenda of elections. We would expect the social-economic issue to have a hard time capturing the electoral agenda, and to have a weak effect on the vote compared to identity-related issues. Socio-economic differences should be less significant in structuring the vote than ethnicity and religiosity (Arab–Jewish, and among Jews, Ashkenazi–Oriental and secular–religious differences).⁵

Previous analysis of the 1996 election exhibited precisely this pattern with regard to the Jewish electorate (Shamir and Arian, 1999a) (Tables 1, 2 and 3). Religious observance was the most potent social variable in explaining the vote for Netanyahu versus Peres and for Likud versus Labor. Social-economic indicators were much more weakly and less directly related to the vote. Before the 1977 realignment, religiosity barely distinguished between Labor and Likud voters. With consolidation of the bipolar structure of the party system thereafter, it became more and more important, becoming the leading social distinction in politics (Shamir and Arian, 1999a). Labor and

Table 3. Means of external and internal scales by religious observance, 1996 and 2006

	<i>Internal96</i>	<i>Internal06</i>	<i>External96</i>	<i>External06</i>
<i>Total sample</i>	49.6	46.9	41.6	43.7
Religious	71.1	74.3	56.5	60.0
Traditional	47.1	41.1	39.8	39.5
Secular	29.0	25.9	28.3	32.4

Scales 1 to 100; 1 = Dove, Israeli.
1996 N = 1,039; 2006 N = 1,484.

the left were increasingly seen as anticlerical, while the Likud played to the traditionalist Jewish sympathies of much of its voting base, even though the origins and ideology of the Likud as a political party were clearly secular. Electoral and coalition politics further buttressed the connection between the religious and right-wing parties and blocs since the 1977 turnabout in government.

Of the three major issue domains in Israeli politics, i.e. the territorial issue, state-religion and social-economics, the territorial debate was the most dominant by far in 1996. It has grown in importance since the 1984 election, which was the point in time in which the territory issue emerged as the overriding dimension ordering the party system. Since then, the impact of the territories issue on the vote has remained very high in distinguishing the left from the right and Labor from Likud (Shamir and Arian, 1999a). Over time, Labor identified itself as the territories-for-peace party, and its platforms became less ambiguous on this issue; the left became the 'peace camp', and the right the 'national or nationalistic camp'. Compared to the territorial issue, the socio-economic and religious-secular issues were much less important in structuring the vote, especially since the first Intifada, and their coefficients oscillate in their relative impact during this period. The internal collective identity debate over state-religion relations indeed seems to be of lesser political salience and potency than the external territorial issue, which superimposes itself over all collective identity dilemmas. Nevertheless, it is of course a constant in Israeli politics in the form of the religious parties. In 1999 it came onto the campaign agenda with the struggle between Shas and Israel Baaliya, the Former Soviet Union immigrants' party led by Sharan-sky, over the ministry of the interior. It was even more salient in the 2003 election when the secular anti-Haredi party Shinui brought it onto the electoral agenda and was able to obtain 15 seats in the Knesset. Socio-economic issues did not permeate forcefully (except for 1984) nor replace the external collective identity issue throughout this period (Shamir and Arian, 1999a; Tables 1 and 2).

In the 2006 election, the overall picture did not change: in terms of the social underpinnings of the vote, religiosity still stood out as the most persistent variable determining vote choice. In terms of issue domains, the territorial issue was still the dominant one (Shamir et al., 2008: Appendix).

A unique three-wave panel study enabled us to track voters, their attitudes and their vote intentions from the period prior to the Gaza disengagement in 2005, through the establishment of Kadima and until after the 2006 elections, and thus to explore in depth the sources of support for Kadima, the big winner of the election, established just a few months prior.⁶ According to these and other data, the largest proportion of the Kadima vote came from previous Likud voters, and they were significantly different from Likud loyalists in their attitudes to security and peace issues, with differences reaching 30 to 40 percentage points on some items.⁷ They were more inclined to remove settlements, to support the unilateral disengagement and

to believe that it was possible to reach an agreement with the Arabs. They were also more moderate in their assessment of the aspirations of the Arabs. On the other hand, they differed little on state and religion and socio-economic policy. Multivariate analysis established that, among 2003 Likud voters, affinity for Prime Minister Sharon made a difference in terms of switching to Kadima, but even more so Kadima's more moderate position on peace and security matters, with which they concurred (Shamir et al., 2008: Tables 4 and 5).

This was not the explanation among 2003 Labor voters, for whom socio-economic policy seemed to matter. However, in terms of voters' agendas, the switchers to Kadima – unlike loyal Labor voters – stated that negotiations with the Arabs and the security situation were the topics that most affected how they voted, rather than the socio-economic situation.

This analysis provides support for the dominance of the security/peace dimension in the electoral basis of Kadima in terms of switchers. This conclusion was further supported by analysis of the complete (Jewish) electorate in the 2006 INES data by means of a multinomial logistic regression.⁸ In this analysis, Kadima served as reference in comparison to the other major parties (Meretz, Labor, Likud, Israel Beiteinu, Yahadut Hatorah, Shas, Ihud Leumi-Mafdal), and the vote predictors included socio-demographic background characteristics of voters (education, density of living, age, gender, immigrant versus veteran and religiosity); the issues of territories, state–religion relations and socio-economic policy; prospective performance evaluations in the security, economic and social realms, and affect towards Sharon. Figure 2 presents probabilities of voting for Kadima, Likud and Labor based on this multivariate analysis. The probabilities on the vertical axis are the predicted probabilities of endorsing each of the three parties for a hypothetical 'average' individual given the relevant range of positions on the three issues.⁹

The first panel of the figure presents a voter's inclination to endorse each of the three parties moving from support for territorial compromise as part of a permanent agreement with the Palestinians to opposition to it. As the figure shows, the less a voter is willing to compromise, the less likely she is to endorse Kadima and, even more so, Labor; the likelihood of endorsing Likud, on the other hand, increases. Among the most dovish voters, the highest probability is for voting Labor (and, very close to it, voting for Kadima). Among the two middle categories, Kadima is the most likely choice. Among the three parties, Likud is the most likely choice for the most hawkish respondents.

The second panel of the figure depicts the impact of the socio-economic dimension on the vote for these three parties. Kadima voters are indifferent to this issue dimension. The likelihood of supporting Labor increases with support for socialism, and the opposite holds true for Likud support.

The third panel presents the effect of the relations between religion and state (indicating the internal dimension of identity) on the vote. Here the

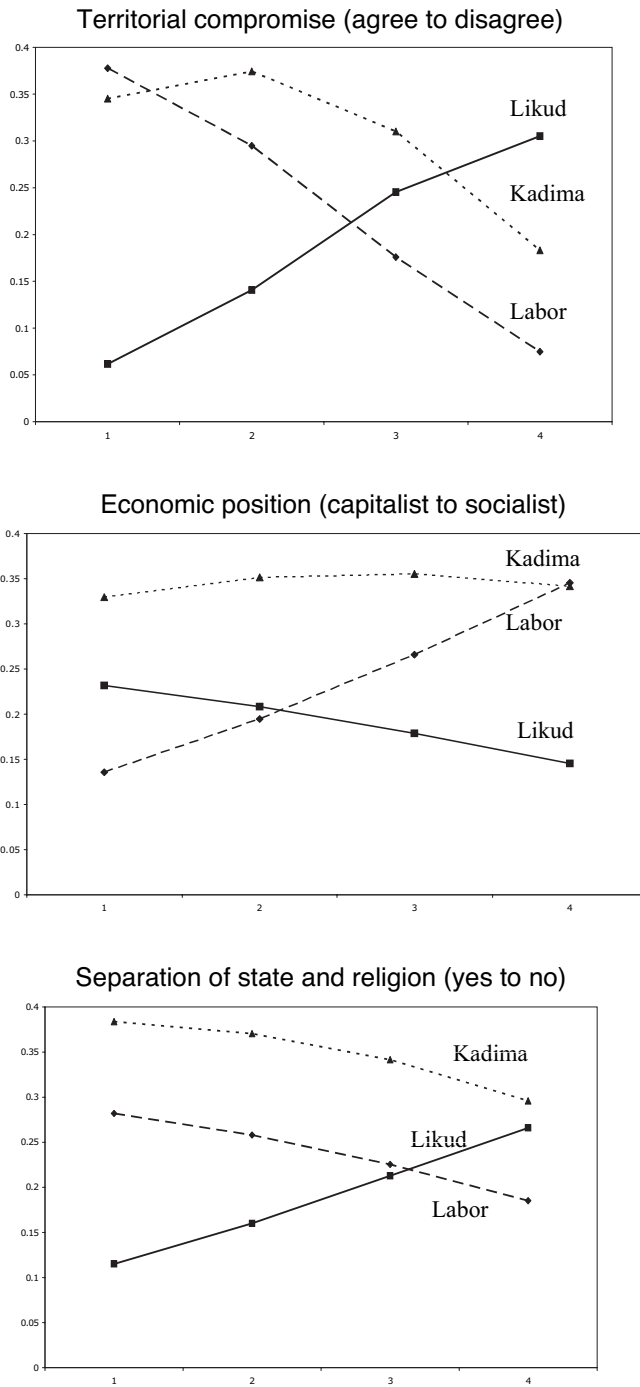


Figure 2. Probabilities of voting Kadima, Labor and Likud, by issue positions

pattern is similar in its general outline to the external dimension of identity in the first panel. Here, too, Labor and Kadima supporters show a mild decline in their vote intention as we move towards involvement of the state in maintaining Jewish life, whereas the likelihood of supporting the Likud increases. However, the potency of this internal identity dimension is much weaker than that of the external dimension – as in previous elections. The differences in probability of voting for the three parties between categories on this variable (illustrated by the slopes of the lines) are much smaller in the third panel than in the first, and the same is true when comparing the second panel with the first. The primacy of the external identity dimension over the other issue dimensions in electoral behaviour is clearly established.

The struggle over the electoral agenda in the 2006 election campaign provides further support for our argument. The election of Amir Peretz, former head of the Histadrut Labor Union, to head the Labor ticket in November 2005 positioned the social-economic agenda in the forefront of the campaign. The campaign started off with clear dominance of this agenda item. In the background was the ongoing policy of severe welfare cuts under the Likud government of Sharon, a policy that was associated primarily with Benjamin Netanyahu, finance minister under Sharon, now head of the Likud. The media and much of the parties' advertising focused on poverty, education, health and welfare (Weimann et al., 2008: Table 6). However, as the campaign unfolded, and especially after the elections to the Palestinian Legislative Council in early 2006 which Hamas won, the grip of the socio-economic agenda loosened, and security and foreign affairs tied or took the lead in terms of voters' campaign perceptions and personal agenda (Shamir et al., 2007; Table 3). In voters' actual vote considerations, as we saw, peace and security concerns dominated once more.

Kadima as a Centre Party

The establishment, positioning and success of Kadima must be understood within the contours of the fundamental policy-making and politics-making dilemmas we illuminated at the beginning of this article. Kadima was the organizational representation of the unilateral concept and policy, and cannot be divorced from the 2005 Gaza disengagement. Our focus on Kadima is designed to further illuminate the sturdiness of the cleavage structure and the meaning of left, right and centre in current Israeli politics.

The disengagement is Sharon's heritage, but it was not his idea nor was he the first to implement it. Just five years before the Gaza disengagement there was the unilateral withdrawal from Southern Lebanon in 2000 under Prime Minister Ehud Barak. As a matter of fact, Sharon won the 2003 election against Amram Mitzna, who ran at the head of the Labor Party on a platform of unilateral withdrawal from Gaza. His programme was to strengthen Israel's security by disconnecting from the Arab territories and

population bases. The voters rejected this plan totally, giving Ariel Sharon of the Likud an overwhelming victory in that election. And yet Sharon's unilateral disengagement from the Gaza Strip in 2005 echoed Mitzna's plan closely. Olmert's convergence plan, presented in detail to the public during the 2006 election campaign, took these ideas further, transposing them to the West Bank as well. However, just a few months after the 2006 election, the policy of unilateral disengagement had become obsolete after Hamas's rise to power in the Palestinian Authority in January 2006, the Kassam rockets fired from the Gaza Strip into Southern Israel and the second Lebanon war in the summer of 2006. Sharon's Gaza disengagement did not produce the hoped-for results. The call for unilateral actions negated decades of Zionist demands for recognition and negotiation as conditions for concessions. Opponents of the plan argued that the tactic had not worked to decrease the belligerence of the other side or to stabilize new borders after the withdrawal. Cynics accused Sharon of using the unilateral disengagement as a means to distract attention from accusations levelled against him and his sons for illegal recruitment of campaign funds and for accepting bribes.

The Kadima party, established only a few months before the 2006 elections by Ariel Sharon soon after the Gaza disengagement, positioned itself as a centre party. Previously, when a party of the centre emerged it tended to stress non-security planks in its platform. Shinui in 2003, with its large 15-seat victory, was a good example of this, as was the Democratic Movement for Change (DMC) that won the centre of the political map in 1977 also gaining 15 Knesset seats. This was not the case with Kadima. Kadima came to the elections with a platform which was already being put into effect by Sharon. In 2005 post-disengagement Israel, Sharon was inescapably associated with the disengagement and with unilateralism, as was Kadima. Kadima ran its campaign on the security and peace dimension, and presented an explicit policy alternative of unilateralism and disengagement.¹⁰

The unilateral withdrawal from Gaza and Sharon's leaving Likud were the catalysts for the formation of Kadima, but they offer only a partial explanation. It is likely that Kadima would not have been established without Sharon, but it is also true that Kadima was more than a one-man show, and it would not have endured had it not been for its resonance with the public's preferences on the external identity dimension. Perhaps the best evidence was its continued existence after Sharon's strokes removed him from the political scene. The party tapped into fertile soil in offering the Israeli electorate a party alternative that epitomized the median voter's stance on the major cleavage dimension – a specific combination of the left and the right: a growing willingness for compromise from the left together with deep mistrust of the Palestinians (and Arabs in general) from the right. These were the distinctive features of Sharon's policy and heritage embodied in the unilateral disengagement and the separation fence. This is the thrust of the meaning of the centre in Israel today – falling between Labor and Likud and between left and right: a pragmatic but wary middle ground (Hazan, 2007;

Shamir et al., 2008). The specific platform of unilateral disengagement detailed well-defined foreign and security policies, but this pragmatic wary centre extends well beyond this specific policy alternative, and the Olmert government's later policies fall under it squarely.

The interpretation of Kadima as such a centre party is well supported by a thorough examination of its electoral base (Shamir et al., 2008). INES respondents were asked to place themselves on a 1–7 right–left scale shortly before the elections in March 2006. The order of parties we obtained spread across almost the full spectrum and corresponded to common placement of the political parties in Israeli politics. Kadima voters were located pretty much in the middle of the scale (3.93).

Left and right are defined in Israel primarily by security and peace issues, and indeed the same order of party electorates was obtained relative to peace and security issues, and here too the Kadima electorate's policy positions fell in-between the left and right parties. They were similar to Labor voters in terms of unilateral moves, territorial compromise and the Arab neighbourhoods of Jerusalem. Regarding the concessions to which they were ready to agree (such as the evacuation of settlements in Judea and Samaria or withdrawal from the Golan Heights), the Kadima voters were somewhere in-between the Likud and Labor groups; they rejected solutions that called for 'not one inch' and for complete withdrawal. They were also between the other two groups in their assessment of Arab aspirations. This is the centre in Israeli politics, tapped in the 2006 election by Kadima, and it provides its leadership with ample opportunity to go both to peace and to war.

Conclusions

Cleavage is a useful concept because it allows focus on the attempts by parties and leaders to interact with the electorate in order to maximize their vote-share. Cleavage is based on a real difference, projected and manipulated to reflect values and goals, and repackaged in a manner that indicates how public policy will take its demands into account.

Israel of recent decades is a case where a specific cleavage overpowers a political system, its organizations and its major actors. One can bring arguments that Israel's grip on the territories has Biblical, philosophical, theological or strategic implications. Here we focused attention on the fact that the territories cleavage has overwhelmed other dimensions of Israeli political competition, making the expectation unrealistic that other real social, economic, environmental, ethnic and religious problems will usurp this king of cleavages in the foreseeable future. Its sturdiness lies in its collective identity essence, and such concerns in general are more likely to become full cleavages and to dominate and endure.

All political systems magnify the power of one group or one leader and dash the aspirations of others. In that sense, Israel is no different from other

systems. What is amazing in Israel 40 years after the introduction of the territories into the Israeli political agenda is the vice-like grip it has maintained over the agenda, over the fortunes of groups and individuals, and especially over the outcome. Short-circuiting the historic clash between the Orthodox religious vision and a more secular, modern, viewpoint, these issues have been cauterized to the debates over the territories without clarifying points of view on either side. Even straightforward economic issues, such as the perpetuation of Israel's welfare state, become entwined in issues of God-given mandates, and bleak posts on bleaker hilltops. The mountains do not skip like rams on the road to peace, nor the little lambs in the historic reconciliation of fractions of the Jewish people (Psalms 114: 4). But the territories dwelleth securely.

Obviously things have changed between 1996 and 2006 and since. Sharon is no longer part of Israeli politics, and the policy of unilateralism has become obsolete. Sharon's Gaza disengagement did not produce a bypass solution for the territories, and Olmert's convergence plan will likely never be tested. The unique policy blend Kadima offered dissipated, but not the fuzzy yet real, pragmatic, conciliatory but wary centre in the Israeli electorate, which has only grown over the decade we examined. It was the key to the success of Kadima in the 2006 election, and it still makes up the median Israeli voter. Kadima was a timely response of the party system to voter preferences, grounded in policy, and, as we have shown, indeed many voters of moderate and middle-of-the-road views on the Israeli–Arab conflict found their place in Kadima. The 2006 elections were characterized by a dramatic change in party balance, suggesting to some a realignment in the making. We disagree. As a matter of fact, since the early 1990s the once stable, even frozen, Israeli party system has exhibited enormous change: repeated turn-overs in government, the rise and fall of old and new parties, volatility, weakening partisanship and fluidity of parties. The Israeli party system has undergone dealignment, and the striking success of Kadima was made possible by the depth of this dealignment (Shamir et al., 2008; and see Arian et al., 2006). Yet, based on our cleavage analysis, we suggest that the Israeli party system is still governed by the 1977 realignment.

The restructuring of the party system in 2006 was unmistakably along the major cleavage dimension of Israeli politics, and was buttressed by the prevailing social divides of religiosity, class and ethnicity. Their role did not change; if anything, it may even have been heightened (Shamir et al., 2008). The shifting vote patterns were not grounded in changing social coalitions or issue dimensions, they built upon and restated the existing ones. No significant new dimension emerged, nor was there any indication of a shake-up of the traditional social bases of the vote. The social-economic agenda promoted by Amir Peretz, which seemed to eclipse security concerns early on in the campaign, lost its lead as the campaign dragged on. The social-economic cleavage did not emerge as a significant dimension in most voters' considerations, nor did it materialize in a significant redrawing of the social

basis of the vote. Amir Peretz as Minister of Defence, and the insignificance of Labor in the formulation of social and economic policy in Olmert's government, banished the thought that this cleavage could emerge as a dominant force in Israeli politics in the foreseeable future. The territories, and more essentially the collective identity dilemmas we illuminated in this article, remained the major issues of contention. Kadima is primarily one more milestone on the long road to dealignment of the Israeli party system, and the strong hold of the territories as the primary driver of the Israeli political system.

Notes

- 1 Our argument would be further strengthened were we to consider the total population, including the Arab minority, making up 13 percent of the electorate in 2006 (http://www.cbs.gov.il/hodaot2006n/24_06_061b.doc). The distinction between 'Arab' and 'Jewish' political parties is staunch, voting behaviour of Israeli Arabs is distinct and identity considerations paramount.
- 2 The Israel National Election Study (INES) in 2006 was conducted between 28 February and 23 March 2006. The sample was representative of the Israeli electorate, with N = 1,919 respondents (1,630 Jews, 289 Arabs). In 1996, the survey was carried out between 1 and 27 May, among a representative sample of the electorate, excluding Kibbutzim and localities beyond the 1967 Green Line (N = 1,168 Jews, 503 Arabs). Only Jewish respondents are analysed here.
- 3 For the wording of the questions, see Shamir and Arian (1999a). The two scales were constructed following an exploratory factor analysis, which clearly established the two dimensions as well as their strong interrelationship (Shamir and Arian, 1999b, Table 2.1). The two value priority indicators (Greater Israel priority and democracy priority) are based on a ranking question in which respondents were asked to rank four values from most to least important (Israel with a Jewish majority, Greater Israel, a democratic state and peace) (*ibid.*, p. 48). Greater Israel priority loaded on the external dimension factor, democracy priority loaded on the internal dimension factor and the Jewish majority and peace priorities loaded on a third factor, unrelated to these two divisive identity factors, which we interpreted as a consensus valence dimension (*ibid.*, pp. 51–2).
- 4 In 1996, the interviews were conducted face to face and in Hebrew (among Jews). In 2006, the survey was by telephone and the interviews were conducted among Jews in Hebrew and Russian.
- 5 Shalev and Kis, who studied the role of class in electoral behaviour and demonstrated class effects, commented that in Israel 'the most obvious correlates of these class-voting linkages are non-economic: disputed issues of collective identity, the role of religion in personal and national life, and management of the peace process and future borders' (2002: 91). In other words, while 'struggles over identity and borders are by no means detached from class interests' (*ibid.*), class effects are mediated by them and do not by themselves directly determine electoral behaviour.
- 6 For details, see Shamir et al. (2008).
- 7 These items were measured in the first panel wave in July 2005.
- 8 For detailed analysis, see Shamir et al. (2008).

- 9 Respondents' positions on territorial compromise, government involvement in the economy and state-religion relations are varied, while setting all other variables at their means. Nominal variables are set such that the hypothetical respondent is a female, and not an immigrant from the former Soviet Union.
- 10 This was implicit, with Sharon at its head; explicit, with Olmert (see Shamir et al., 2007).

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